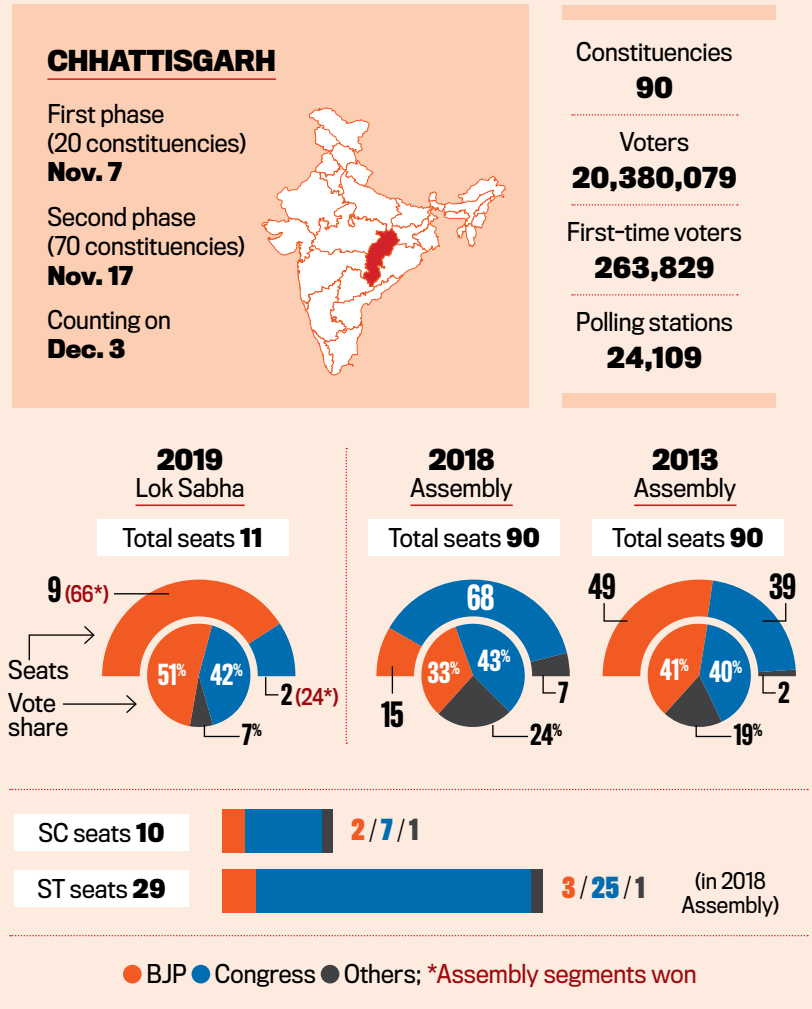


farmers. In 2022-23, the centrally-announced minimum support price, or MSP, stood at just Rs 2,040 and Rs 2,060 per quintal for the two paddy varieties. Under the scheme, the state government pays the balance to the farmers in four equal instalments. As an added incentive, for the upcoming 2023-24 season, Baghel has increased the cap on paddy procurement from each farmer from 15 quintals per acre to 20 quintals per acre. Meanwhile, farmers who don't sow paddy get Rs 10,000 per acre as an input subsidy. Then there is a scheme to pay Rs 6,000 per annum to landless farmhands.

All these schemes cover a majority of the population living in the 65 or so rural seats, mostly in the state's central region. This is also the Other Backward Class (OBC)-dominated region, where Baghel—himself an OBC—feels he can gain substantially. So, as the BJP bets on the Sahu community, the biggest OBC group in the state, the Congress is stitching up a Kurmi-Yadav-Marar-Agharia Patel-Kewat alliance to upend its plans. Baghel feels that with his pro-rural schemes and the traditional tribal support that the Congress enjoys in 14 seats in north Chhattisgarh and 12 in the south, he will be able to pull through. To further ingratiate himself with the tribal voters, the CM has enhanced the list of minor forest produce procured by the government, besides hiking the tendu leaf-plucking wages. He has also commissioned the construction of facilities at *devgudis*—sites revered by tribal communities—in both north and south regions.

Invoking 'Chhattisgarhi pride' is another major cultural project that has been unfolding under Baghel in the past few years. It involves the promotion of the Chhattisgarhi language, cuisine, art, festivals and even sports. An underlying and closely interrelated theme, though not spoken about openly, is the opposition to business communities and their projection as exploiters of the innocent locals. That the BJP has a large number of leaders from the business community only helps Baghel. This focus on the state's culture also helps Baghel blunt the BJP's Hindutva agenda, which has often come to the fore at the saffron party's programmes against church groups in tribal areas and Muslims in urban areas.

Another card up Baghel's sleeve is 'soft Hindutva', under which he has ordered the development of the Ram Van Gaman Path, that is, the section of the route falling within Chhattisgarh that Lord Ram is believed to have taken during his *vanvas*. Then, under the rather radical Godhan Nyay Yojana, the state government is procuring cow dung and urine from cattle owners through a network of gauthans, or cow hubs, created in villages. It is further supplied to women's self-help groups that turn it into paint, vermicompost and other products, which the government buys back from them.

But lest you think the going will be easy for Baghel, there's plenty that can throw a spanner in the works. For one, there is a perceptible anti-incumbency sentiment against some Congress MLAs, especially the first-timers. The CM plans to pit this anti-incumbency against a visible pro-incumbency in his favour, as corroborated by the India Today Political Stock Exchange. The survey found that a whopping 77 per cent of the respondents in Chhattisgarh were satisfied with the state government's performance while 78 per cent gave a thumbs-up to Baghel.

The CM will also have to deny tickets to the sitting MLAs who face anti-incumbency, which will only lead to infighting. Maybe that's the reason the Congress has not named a single